

Session 23: Gog and the Snake

Key Takeaways

- Gog represents opposition to God's purposes from all the other nations that have not entered Israel's story.
- For God to bring blessing to the whole world, he must confront the influence of the snake in all the nations.
- Ancestry doesn't determine who we are before God. How we respond to God determines our relationship with God.

Yahweh's Victory Over Evil Among the Nations

In [Ezekiel 38-39](#) two great themes from earlier in the book are taken up.

1. The restoration of Israel as Yahweh's covenant people so that his glorious presence that left the temple can be restored.
2. The restoration of Yahweh's tarnished reputation among the nations due to Israel's disobedience and exile.

Ezekiel 38-48 addresses these themes in reverse order.

The Gog Oracles

These chapters are a hiatus between the promise of a future temple in [Ezekiel 37:26-28](#) and its realization in chapters 40-48. The subject is how Yahweh will deal with the still existing threat of evil and rebellion among the nations as part of his plan to restore his world. After Yahweh has dealt with evil among his own covenant people, he turns his attention to the nations to do the same.

The key text that these chapters look back to is the central oracle of the oracles against the nations, [Ezekiel 28:25-26](#), which was not about the nations, but about Yahweh's vindication of Israel in the eyes of the nations who had scorned them. Specifically, it said that Israel would be restored back to its land, living securely "when I execute judgment upon all those round about them who scorn them" ([28:26](#)). It seems that chapters [38-39](#) take up this earlier unique idea of a further divine defeat of rebellious nations after Israel's restoration, and develop and expand upon it further.

The oracles are structured as two large panels, each consisting of four distinct sections with parallel introductions (in [Ezek. 38:1-4](#) and [39:1-2](#)) and conclusions ([Ezek. 38:23](#) and [39:21-29](#)). The flow of the oracles does not follow a linear logic, and the chapters are full of allusive language and imagery from earlier prophetic oracles along with grotesque, extreme images.

The Symmetrical Design of Ezekiel 38–39

The Defeat of Gog: Take 1	The Defeat and Disposal of Gog: Take 2
38:1-9: Gog and his army are summoned by Yahweh to the mountains of Israel “Son of man, set your face against Gog ... and prophesy against him and say, ‘Thus says Yahweh, Look I am against you Gog, head ruler of Meshek and Tuval, and I will lead you out ...’”	39:1-8: Gog and his army are summoned and defeated by Yahweh on the mountains of Israel “And you Son of man, prophesy against Gog and say, ‘Thus says Yahweh, Look I am against you Gog, head ruler of Meshek and Tuval, and I will lead you out ...’”
38:10-13: Gog’s motives: to get plunder “Have you come to plunder plunder? Have you gathered your gathering to despoil the spoil?” (38:12)	39:9-16: Gog’s remains are burned, plundered, and then buried “And [the residents of Israel] will plunder their plunderers, and they will get spoil from those who got spoil from them.” (39:10)
38:14-16: Gog and his army are summoned by Yahweh so that the nations acknowledge Yahweh	39:17-24: Gog’s remains are consumed in a sacrificial feast
38:17-23: The four-fold defeat of Gog Earthquake, sword, plague, and flood & fire “And I will show myself as great, and I will show myself as holy, and I will be acknowledged in the eyes of the nations and you will acknowledge that I am Yahweh.” (38:23)	39:25-29: Yahweh is acknowledged among Israel and the nations when he defeats Gog and restores Israel “And I will show myself as holy through them in the eyes of many nations, and they will acknowledge that I am Yahweh their God.” (39:27-28)
<i>The Defeat of Gog.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).	

The Scriptural Roots of the Gog Oracles

These two chapters are the end result of a long-developing theme that began in Genesis 3, with the deceptive snake and the promise of perpetual hostility between the seed of the snake and the seed of the woman.

Genesis 3:14-15 NASB*

¹⁴ And Yahweh *Elohim* said to the snake,
“Because you have done this,
you are cursed more than all cattle,
and more than every beast of the field;
on your belly you will go,
and dust you will eat
all the days of your life;

¹⁵ And **I will put hostility between you and the woman,**
and between your seed and her seed;
he shall strike your head,
and you shall strike his heel.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This promise of perpetual hostility between the lineage of God’s promise and the lineage of the deceptive spiritual powers at work in creation is developed in the following narrative of Adam and Eve’s three sons: the brothers Cain, Abel, and Seth.

Cain is consumed by an animal called “sin” that compels him to murder the seed of the woman. Cain's lineage leads to the founding of the city of blood in Genesis 4:17-24 and the lineage of Tubal-Qayin. Adam and Eve’s lineage restarts with Seth which leads to the worship of Yahweh (Gen. 4:26).

This “sibling hostility” between the seed of the woman and the seed of the snake continues in the story of Noah, a new Adam figure, who also has three sons who end up at odds with each other after the blessings and curses issued by their father.

Genesis 9:25-27 Instructor's Translation

²⁵ And he said:
“Cursed be **Canaan**,
a **servant of servants**
he will be **to his brothers**.”

²⁶ And he said:
“Blessed be Yahweh,
God of **Shem**,
and may Canaan be a **servant to him/them**.

²⁷ May God enlarge **Japheth**,
and may he dwell in the tents of **Shem**
and may **Canaan** be a **servant to him/them**.”

A Future for Japheth ... and Shem ... and Canaan

Noah’s word that God would “enlarge” (יָפַת) Japheth plays on his name in Hebrew, Yepheth (יֶפֶת). The name comes from the root *patah* = “to make large.” Noah anticipates that Japheth’s territory will be expanded in the future.

The enlarging of Japheth invites the reader to study the list of Japheth's descendants in Genesis 10:2-5.

Genesis 10:2-5 NASB*

² The sons of Japheth:

Gomer and Magog and Madai and Javan and Tubal and Meshech and Tiras.

³ The sons of Gomer were Ashkenaz and Riphath and Togarmah.

⁴ The sons of Javan were Elishah and Tarshish, Kittim and Dodanim.

⁵ From these the islands of the nations were separated into their lands ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Here we find tribes and nations that mostly make up ancient Anatolia (Roman Asia Minor, modern Turkey) and Greece. Noah anticipates that these tribes and nations will enlarge their territory and make their way into the territory of Shem.

"May he dwell in the tents of Shem" could be interpreted in two different ways.

"To displace, to disinherit"

There are some contexts where one group "dwelling in the tent" of another is the result of conflict and dispossession.

Psalms 78:55 NASB

[Yahweh] also drove out the nations before them, and apportioned them for an inheritance by measurement, and made the tribes of Israel **dwell in their tents**.

1 Chronicles 5:10 NASB*

In the days of Saul they made war with the Hagarites, who fell by their hand, so that they **dwelt in their tents** throughout all the land east of Gilead.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

On this reading, Noah's words anticipate a future conflict between all of his children where Japheth dispossesses Shem from his tent and makes Canaan his slave. Many texts throughout the Hebrew Bible activate this meaning. For example, this meaning is possible when the nations at war with Israel are from Japheth, or when a future conflict is anticipated between Israel and the nations.

In Genesis 14, five kings of the east (two from Ham and two from Japheth) come to enslave four rebellious kings of Canaan. In the conflict, Lot, a descendant of Shem, is taken captive. Abram, a son of Shem, and two Canaanite allies defeat the five kings and restore the captives. The Canaanite priest king Melchizedek also appears in this narrative, and he worships the creator God and blesses Abram.

The pagan prophet Balaam speaks about the future conflict between Noah's sons (Num. 24:23-24). He speaks of a descendant of Japheth, the Kittim, who will come to oppress Asshur (from Ham and Shem) and Eber (from Shem).

This conflict is expanded and developed in Daniel 7:12 in the sequence of empires leading up to the final beast and horn that will displace the sons of Ham (Assyria and Babylon) and Shem (the Israelites) in terms of

political power in the land promised to Abraham.

Noah's blessing on Japheth and its relation to the table of nations in Genesis 10 is also behind Ezekiel's fascinating oracle about Gog of Magog. Magog is a seed of Japheth and rules over his brothers Meshek and Tubal. He also brings the sons of Ham (Cush and Put) and non-Israelite sons of Shem (Persia/Elam) as mercenaries in his war with Israel after its restoration from exile. Ezekiel brings together the common Day of Yahweh motif where Yahweh destroys the seed of the serpent from among the nations (see [Isa. 13-14](#); [Joel 3-4](#); [Zech. 14](#)).

"To live together with"

Living in the same tent is an image of unity in some texts.

Psalm 15:1 NIV*

Yahweh, who may **dwelt in your sacred tent**? Who may live on your holy mountain?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The ideal state of God's covenant people is to "dwell in his tent," that is, to live with him in peace and harmony.

Job 11:14-15 NIV

¹⁴ If you put away the sin that is in your hand and allow no evil **to dwell in your tent**,

¹⁵ then, free of fault, you will lift up your face; you will stand firm and without fear.

Job's friends accuse him of living in unity with evil, which must be why he's suffering.

Psalm 120:5 NIV

Woe to me that I **dwelt** in Meshek, that I **live among the tents** of Kedar!

The poet laments that he has to live in the tents of Meshek (a descendant of Japheth) and Kedar (a son of Ishmael).

On this reading, Noah's words anticipate a day when all of his sons will live together in peace so that the "nations" (sons of Japheth) would be incorporated into the "tents of Shem," that is, experience Yahweh's covenant blessings.

- Genesis [12:1-3](#), [17:3-8](#), and [22:15-18](#) all point to this incorporation of the nations into the blessing of Abraham's family.
- [Isaiah 2:1-4](#) and [chapter 60](#) depict this gathering of the nations to live in the new Jerusalem and experience its abundance.
- [Zechariah 2:10-13](#) and [8:23](#) depict this same inclusion of the nations in the post-exile restoration of God's covenant people.

Zechariah 2:10-11 NASB

¹⁰ “Sing for joy and be glad, O daughter of Zion; for behold I am coming and I will dwell in your midst,” declares the LORD. ¹¹ “Many nations will join themselves to the LORD in that day and will become my people. Then I will dwell in your midst, and you will know that the LORD of hosts has sent me to you.”

Interestingly, Zechariah 14 brings together both potential meanings of Genesis 9:27. First there is a great conflict between the sons of Noah, resulting in a remnant among the nations that comes to the new Jerusalem to experience its Eden blessings.

Zechariah 14:1-3, 9-11, 16 NASB*

¹ Behold, a day is coming for Yahweh when the spoil taken from you will be divided among you. ² For I will gather all the nations against Jerusalem to battle ... ³ Then Yahweh will go forth and fight against those nations, as when he fights on a day of battle. ...

⁹ And the LORD will be King over all the earth; in that day Yahweh will be the only one, and his name the only one. ¹⁰ All the land will be changed into a plain from Geba to Rimmon south of Jerusalem; but Jerusalem will rise and remain on its site from Benjamin's Gate as far as the place of the First Gate to the Corner Gate, and from the Tower of Hananel to the king's wine presses. ¹¹ People will live in it, and there will no longer be a curse, for Jerusalem will dwell in security. ...

¹⁶ Then it will come about that any who are remaining of all the nations that went against Jerusalem will go up from year to year to worship the King, Yahweh of hosts, and to celebrate the Feast of Booths.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

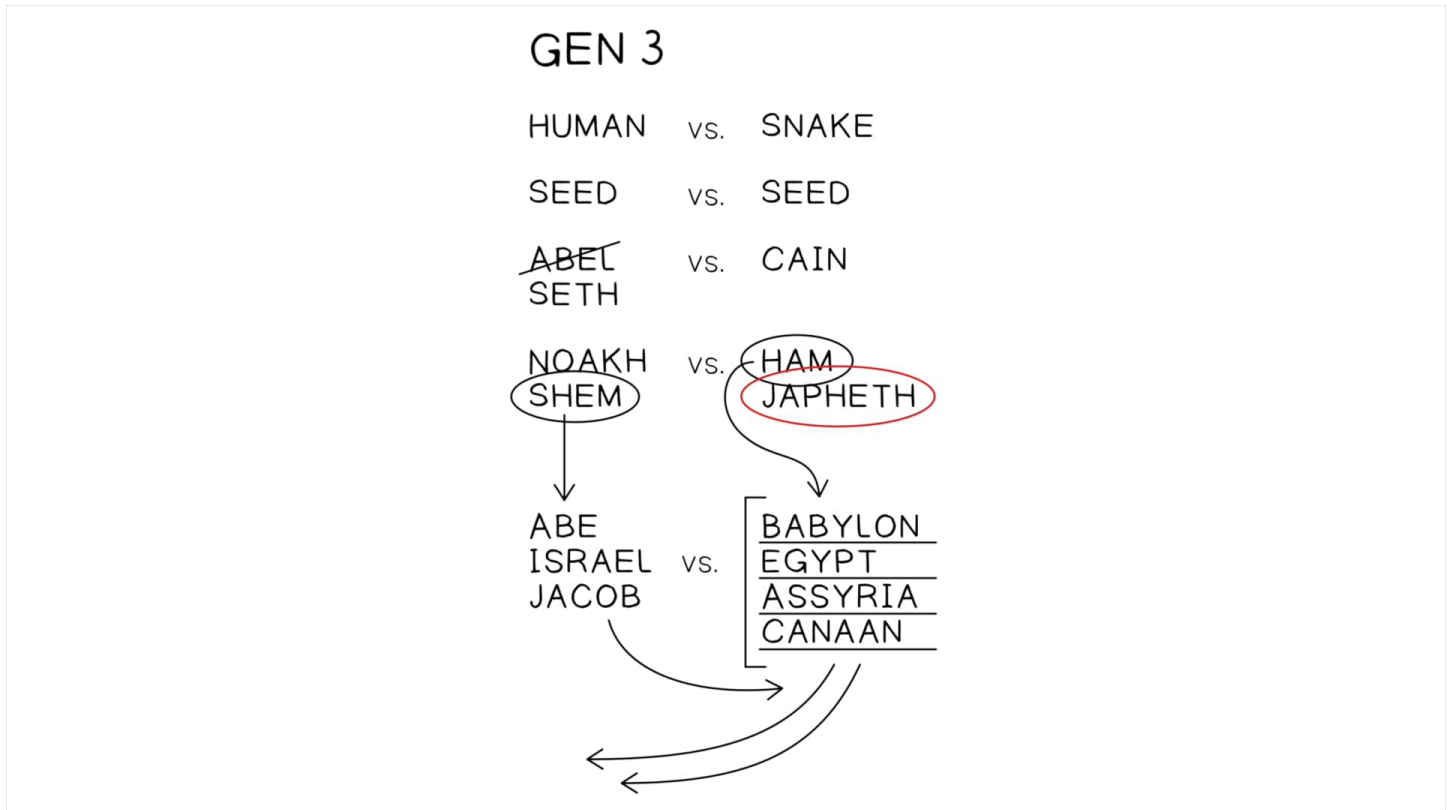
“If the dwelling of Japheth in the tents of Shem presupposes the conquest of the land of Shem by Japheth, it is a blessing not only to Japheth, but to Shem also, since, whilst Japheth enters into the spiritual inheritance of Shem, he brings to Shem all the good of this world (see Isa. 60). ‘The fulfilment,’ as Delitzsch says, ‘is plain enough, for we are all Japhethites dwelling in the tents of Shem; and the language of the New Testament is the language of Javan entered into the tents of Shem.’ ... Moreover it is true of the blessing and curse of Noah, as of all prophetic utterances, that they are fulfilled with regard to the nations and families in question as a whole, but do not predict, like an irresistible fate, the unalterable destiny of every individual; on the contrary, they leave room for freedom of personal decision, and no more cut off the individuals in the accursed race from the possibility of conversion, or close the way of salvation against the penitent, than they secure the individuals of the family blessed against the possibility of falling from a state of grace, and actually losing the blessing. Hence, whilst a Rahab and an Araunah were received into the fellowship of Jehovah, and the Canaanitish woman was relieved by the Lord because of her faith, the hardened Pharisees and scribes had woes pronounced upon them, and Israel was rejected because of its unbelief.”

Keil, C.F. and Delitzsch, F. (1996). [*Commentary on the Old Testament, Volume 1*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 101.

Noah's words invite us to ponder this portrait of the future of nations, using the patterns of Genesis 1-11 to anticipate just where the story is going. The table of nations, then, becomes a palette of future hope. The stories to follow, from Genesis 11 to the end of 2 Kings, all work out the programmatic poems in Genesis 3:14-15 and 9:25-27. There will be hostility between the seed of the woman and the seed of the snake.

- When the nations are at war, they are giving in to the power of the snake that is luring them into jealous and angry violence (see “Gog of Magog” in [Ezek. 38-39](#)).
- When the nations become a “tent of Yahweh,” then humanity will see that they are brothers who can live together in peace ([Ps. 133](#); [Isa. 2:1-4](#)).

Woman Versus Snake



Woman Vs. Snake. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How do God’s curse on the snake ([Gen. 3:15](#)) and Noah’s curse and blessings on his sons ([Gen. 9:25-27](#)) form the scriptural background for the Gog oracles ([Ezek. 38-39](#))?